any money or try to influence a game, I couldn't quite work out why I had been fined substantially more than Henry.

Sixty thousand rand was a lot of money, but nothing compared with what I would lose by not playing for six months. Under the circumstances, I guess I can understand the UCB's desire to make an example of us.

As Donné pointed out to me in no uncertain terms, I could've been banned for life, and then I would've been well and truly – sorry, again there's only one word for it – fucked. 'Just accept the sentence and say thank you,' said Donné. 'And apologise, obviously.'

While I was expecting a monetary fine, getting banned for six months meant I *really* lost out on a lot of money. So, ja – it was a little harsher than I'd anticipated, but I could handle it. Which is what a well-thought-out punishment should be, I suppose.

Those next six months were both good and bad; bad because it was quite embarrassing to go out in public. The match-fixing saga had turned into something way bigger than I could have possibly conceived, and it's not easy knowing that you have let your teammates, your family and your friends down. The upside was that I got to play a lot of golf, which helped keep my mind occupied. I reckon during those first three weeks I probably played golf for 19 days. It really helped to get me hooked on the sport.

Fortunately I was banned only from playing international cricket, so I could still play for my domestic team, Western Province – or the Cape Cobras, as we're now known. It would help make the transition back into the international arena a lot easier than if I hadn't played any cricket at all. Graham Ford was the Proteas coach then, and he remains one of my favourites. He's a very low-key, chilled coach, and I never got the feeling during my ban, from either him or the UCB, that they would shun me once the ban was over. As soon as the six months were up, I was invited back into the fold and the guys were genuinely happy to see me again.

Still, it took a couple of months for me to settle in at that level of cricket again. Fortunately my first Test back, in January 2001, was at Newlands against Sri Lanka. I was very happy to play in front of my home crowd that day, but the first morning was still nerve-wracking. We would bat first, and I wondered what kind of reception I could expect. Thankfully the crowd was great – I got the odd chirp, but it wouldn't be Newlands without it, now would it?